



mobile watch

Tencent to a billion

Chinese social network Tencent has exceeded \$1 billion in revenue in a single year.

iPhone OS 3.0 Out!

iPhone users (and fanboys alike) now have new ammo to defend their beloved iPhone from its detractors. The ammo we're talking about comes in the form of the new iPhone OS3 which promises to cover up all the minor flaws that previously plagued the iPhone. This OS, which is Apple's third major release for the iPhone, boasts of more than a 100 features which include search, copy-paste, MMS, landscape keyboard and stereo Bluetooth. While the OS will be available to regular folks this "summer", Apple has already released a beta with a new SDK comprising over a thousand API function calls. So developers the world over can get their elbows dirty with the new OS starting immediately. The OS will be available for iPhones as a free update and at \$10 for the iPod Touch.

Here's a look at the features that comprise this version 3 OS. Note though — after going through the list you'll realise that many of these functions are really quite basic and in fact, essential. So whether you're an iPhone user or not, it'll make you wonder why Apple couldn't come up with them in the first place.

Spotlight search

Users can now use a comprehensive search function to scour through all of the core applications on the iPhone — such as Mail, Messages, Calendar entries and the song library. Flicking the home screen to the left will bring up a search bar. Once the user begins to enter a term, the phone will search sequentially through Contacts and other applications, to bring up results. Selecting a search result will automatically launch it in the application that the result was picked up from. This Spotlight search can even be used as a filter to search for a particular application; useful for users who have several pages of application icons.

Copy-Paste (It's about time!)

The much missed copy-paste function seems pretty nifty. To select a block of text just tap, and a selection box appears

around it. At the corners of the selection you get grab points to re-size the said box. The function has cross-application support, so you can go crazy with copying text from all over the place. Even a bunch of photos can be selected, copied and pasted into an email. The lack of simple copy-paste functionality has always been

Loose Change

A few other useful features thrown in to OS 3

Voice Memos: now use the microphone to record memos. Edit the memo and share it via email or MMS.

Landscape Keyboard: Now available in all key applications, including Mail. Fat fingers rejoice.

Shake to Shuffle: Going the Sony Ericsson way? Shake the iPhone to shuffle songs; pretty useful for listeners on the move.

Safari: Anti-phishing technology and auto-fill.

Better GPS support: App developers can now build applications around Core Location, allowing apps to deliver turn-by turn direction updates.

Parental Controls: Probably means that applications will get ratings.

CalDAV: Sharing scheduling information supported by Yahoo! and Google.

quite the black eye for the iPhone. As to why it took so long, Scott Forstall, the head of iPhone software development said that it's not that easy and there are security issues. Wonder what that means...

MMS

Multimedia Messaging Service, which is common in many basic phones, has now found its way to the iPhone. This means that you can send image-enhanced text messages through your iPhone without using native email, but rather a messaging service. Although it allows images, there's a lack of video support which is found in most other MMS capable phones. Something for the next update, eh Apple?



Peripheral app support

The iPhone dock connector has been freed, that is to say the 3.0 update will allow developers access to third-party hardware peripherals. So we can expect FM dongles soon. And as shown off in the press conference at Apple's headquarters in Cupertino, an attachment that reads a patient's blood pressure that is controllable via the phone's interface instead of the attached device.

In-app payments

This new system allows users to purchase additional content from within an application. For instance, an expansion pack for a game you have bought could now be sold as an add-on; just buy it from within the app and carry on playing. It was demoed at the press conference using Sims 3 which lets users buy items for in-game characters. This introduction of a micropayment model should be another feather in Apple's money-making cap, as Apple still gets to keep 30 per cent of whatever the developer charges.

Stereo Bluetooth and P2P connectivity

Bluetooth P2P is a feature exclusively developed for the iPhone 3G. With it, devices will be able to connect to each other via Apple's Bonjour technology. So, expect users to be able to play multiplayer games, and perhaps even share files without being connected to a Wi-Fi network. The transmission channel will be iPhone's built-in Bluetooth antenna.

Push Notification

The Push Notification feature provides developers a way to alert users of new information, even when an application is not running, through a push server. Developers can make apps that will make use of text notifications, can trigger audible alerts, or add a numbered badge to the application's icon. Apple is admittedly late on this one, but better late than never, right? ■

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